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Nine Computer Science seniors at West Chester University are building a chatbot for my HR office as their capstone project, under the direction of Dr. Ngo. We're mid-build, and I'm already convinced this is one of the better things I've been part of during my tenure at WCU.

These students aren't writing code for a course or for fun. They have a client. That client is the Office of Human Resources, and we have opinions. The chatbot has to do something useful, on a timeline, within a limited budget. It has to account for data security, accessibility, and the integrity of the information it serves. Those constraints aren't the hypothetical of a classroom experience. They're the constraints every student developer will face the day after commencement.

That's what makes capstone work different from coursework. Their coursework taught them how to build. As client we get to help teach them how to build something that actually works for us and our colleagues.

I'm learning too. Working alongside these students has given me a closer look at how technology moves from concept to product. How decisions get sequenced. Where tradeoffs live. How developers work through problems. Turns out developer tradeoffs come down to the same thing everything else does: time, money, and quality. Pick two.

WCU is full of these opportunities if you go looking. Your next collaboration might be in the building next door. Who can you partner with to give other students their experiential learning?

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